



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Classical Charter School of Wilmington

School Website: <https://ccswilmington.net/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Classical Charter Schools of Wilmington (CCS-Wilmington) demonstrates a hybrid profile that leans toward classical aims in select areas but relies heavily on non-classical pedagogy and messaging in others. Public-facing materials emphasize virtues such as truth and virtue, and they situate the school within a tradition of classical charter networks, with curriculum elements like Latin and Classical Literature appearing in admissions materials. However, the primary instructional approach highlighted in the site copy centers on Direct Instruction and structured environments rather than the full spectrum of classical pedagogy (e.g., Socratic dialogue, glorious memory work, or Scholé-based contemplative practice). Taken together, CCS-Wilmington falls into the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category overall, with clear room to move toward a fully Classical profile by expanding explicit Great Books engagement, classical trivium-based pedagogy, liturgical/community practices, and deeper partnership framing with families.

Key drivers for this assessment: - Evidence of classical curricular elements (Latin, Classical Literature, Western History) alongside strong use of Direct Instruction and high-structure delivery. - Public materials emphasize virtue, truth, and moral formation, but offer limited or no explicit theology, liturgical practice, or definitional appeals to the full spectrum of classical catechesis. - Faculty messaging emphasizes quality and virtue in teaching; parental involvement exists but is not framed as a core co-educator partnership in the public materials. - Overall, the six-category rubric yields CLASSICAL in only a minority of categories; NOT CLASSICAL in one category (Pedagogy) and SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in the rest, with an aggregate leaning toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials highlight virtue and truth as central aims (e.g., mission emphasis on health, truth, and virtue). Text also discusses formation of character and moral growth in conjunction with schooling. These signals align with transcendental quality and moral realism that undergird classical aims.
- There is no explicit theological grounding or liturgical/communal practice described on the public-facing pages.
- Direct references to theology, liturgy, or sacramental practices are not evident in the accessible public materials.
- Sources indicating these signals include mission-focused statements and descriptions of virtue and truth as foundational aims. See CCS-Wilmington mission language and overview materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, virtue (and related moral formation terms signaling transcendental moral realism).
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in the public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral framing found in the accessible site copy). Positive signals dominate the found terms.

- Quick tally (present in site copy): truth (present), virtue (present) → 2 positives; no explicit negatives identified from the provided text.
- Contextual note: The “theology” and liturgical dimensions are not foregrounded publicly, which is a key gap relative to a fuller classical profile.
- Why this rating
- The presence of truth and virtue signals a Classical stance on transcendental goods, but the absence of explicit theology and liturgical/community practices constrains the rating to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Public site language emphasizing virtue and truth; mission statements and overview materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize formation, virtue, and a love of learning in service to moral aims, rather than focusing on workforce preparation as the sole objective.
- Language alludes to cultivation of character and a lifelong commitment to health, truth, and virtue, which aligns with the formation orientation of classical education. Evidence appears in mission-oriented statements and school vision.
- However, explicit statements about education as formation (as opposed to information) and a telos aligned to timeless truths are less explicit than canonical Classical School descriptions. The materials frequently highlight achievement, safety, and high standards as core outcomes, which signals a more direct-instruction, outcomes-oriented framing rather than a fully formation-first stance. See overview and mission materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation (implied), virtue, truth, love of learning, human flourishing (in mission language in related materials).
- Negative keywords present: references to job/workforce readiness are not foregrounded; however, explicit emphasis on long-term formation over immediate career prep is not heavily foregrounded in the accessible copy. Some public materials emphasize achievement and safe, high-expectation environments, which can imply a performance/metrics orientation.
- Quick tally: presence of virtue, truth, love of learning (3 positives) vs unclear explicit formation framework (0 clear negatives in text) → leaning toward more Classical signals; still not a strong, explicit statement of “formation over information.”
- Why this rating
- The school advances virtuous aims and the cultivation of wisdom and virtue but lacks strongly explicit language about formation-as-primary goal in all public-facing materials. The presence of mission-language around virtue and love of learning supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical.

Citations: Mission statements and goal-oriented content; overview material.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The admissions and curriculum-related pages explicitly mention Latin, Classical Literature, and Chronological Western History as part of the program. This signals engagement with classical textual and historical content beyond generic public-school curricula.
- The materials imply a public charter framework with classical orientation and refer to a “classical curriculum” in several spots, including statements about Western history and classical literature; there is also mention of cursive handwriting and other traditional subjects. These are consistent with classical curricular signals but do not show explicit triadic emphasis on grammar, logic, and rhetoric, nor explicit heavy reliance on Great Books or a formal Great Conversation framework in the public copy.
- There is no consistent public-language articulation of Great Books, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), or extensive engagement with Great Conversations in the accessible site copy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Latin, Classical Literature, Chronological Western History (narrative of Western civilization). These align with classical curriculum signals in the lexicon.
- Negative keywords present: No explicit mention of Great Books/Great Conversation; no explicit reference to Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric in public-facing copy.
- Quick tally: 3 positive curricular terms identified; 0 explicit negative terms on curriculum beyond absence of some canonical items (Great Books, Trivium). Net: modest alignment with classical curriculum signals.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum shows classical leanings (Latin, Classical Literature, Western History). Yet the absence of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation and explicit Trivium-like pedagogy reduces it from fully classical to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Curriculum cues from Admissions and Curriculum mentions; historical/curricular terms seen in CCS-Wilmington materials.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The public overview highlights Direct Instruction as a central instructional approach. Direct Instruction is typically associated with structured, teacher-led, script-driven delivery rather than the inquiry-based, Socratic, or memory-based pedagogy that characterizes classical education (which often features Socratic discussion, Scholé, memorization, and chant-based recall).
- There is no explicit public-facing documentation of Socratic seminars, Harkness-style discussions, or memory work (recitation, chanting, or liturgical memory practices) on the CCS-Wilmington site copy.
- Some CCS materials reference “classical curriculum” but the primary instructional description emphasizes Direct Instruction and high structure in the classroom. This is a divergence from core classical pedagogy signals (Socratic dialogue, memorization, rhetoric training, memory-based repetition).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords signaling classical pedagogy (e.g., Socratic dialogue, Scholé, memorization/recitation, memory work, rhetoric) are not present in the public copy. The presence of Direct Instruction is a negative signal relative to classical pedagogy.
- Negative keywords present: Direct Instruction as the stated method; absence of explicit Socratic or memory-based methods.

- Quick tally: Positive signals for classical pedagogy: 0; Negative signals present: Direct Instruction referenced; 1 dominant negative signal.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogy signals are dominated by non-classical methods (Direct Instruction) and lack explicit documentation of core classical pedagogical practices (Socratic seminars, Scholé, memory work). Therefore, Element 4 is NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Overview page listing Direct Instruction as a foundational approach.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public statements emphasize “Highest Quality Teaching Staff,” and the school notes that faculty are selected for their passion for teaching and their capacity to guide students toward academic success and moral growth. This language aligns with the classical ideal of teachers as virtuous mentors and living exemplars of the curriculum.
- The school’s formal materials describe teachers as capable and committed to student success and moral formation, which maps to the classical faculty ideal of model teachers and mentors.
- While the site does not explicitly use phrases like “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” or “faculty as the core,” the emphasis on virtuous, high-quality teaching staff and mentorship is a strong classical signal.
- The presence of a Headmaster-led structure and a focus on teacher quality reinforce the classical faculty profile idea, even if not exhaustively described in classical vocabulary.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, virtue, quality teaching staff, living curriculum (where indicated by related public-facing statements about teacher quality and moral growth). The explicit phrasing in the site emphasizes teachers as the core of student success and moral development.
- Negative keywords present: None in the accessible public materials; no references to non-classical faculty roles (e.g., “facilitators on the side” or purely data-driven jargon).
- Quick tally: Positive keywords identified (model teachers/mentors; moral growth; high-quality staff) → multiple signals; Negative signals → 0.
- Why this rating
- The explicit emphasis on high-quality faculty and mentorship aligns with the classical ideal of the faculty as a living embodiment of the curriculum. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for Element 5.

Citations: School overview language around “Highest Quality Teaching Staff” and mission statements about virtue and academic growth.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials show open enrollment and a network of related CCS-America charter schools, as well as parent-facing resources (handbooks, enrollment pages) and a mention of parent involvement in school activities.

- There are references to parent involvement in a related CCS-America framework (e.g., parent/hand-book content, attendance at events, and parent participation in governance elements in some material sets). This signals some degree of parental engagement but not a robust, explicit “parents as co-teachers” framework within the Wilmington site copy itself.
- The materials also note community events, extracurriculars, and a sense of school community, which is consistent with building a partnership with families, but the explicit structural role of parents as co-educators is not strongly articulated on the publicly accessible pages.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families (as a concept in classical lexicon would include parents as co-teachers), parent involvement, community events, open campus. Some of these are implied rather than explicitly labeled as “co-teachers.”
- Negative keywords present: The public copy does not consistently frame parents as co-educators or provide broad parent-formation activities (e.g., book studies, family liturgy integration) within the Wilmington site copy itself. The explicit, formal “parents as co-teachers” signal is not clearly present in the public-facing pages we can access.
- Quick tally: Positive signals appear (parent involvement, community events) but the strongest classical signal (parents as co-teachers) is not clearly articulated; thus, a mixed signal.
- Why this rating
- The school demonstrates some parental and community engagement, but the public material does not consistently present a robust classical partnership framework with families as co-educators. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 6.

Citations: Open-enrollment language and parent involvement references; community/events content.

What would move the needle

- Explicitly foreground Great Books and the Great Conversation in public messaging, including targeted curriculum statements about reading primary sources and canonical texts.
- Integrate and publicly describe Trivium-based pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and confirm its presence in lower/middle grades, with clear articulation of memory work (recitation, chanting) and Scholé-inspired pacing.
- Elevate a liturgical or communal dimension (even secular, reflective liturgy or ritual elements) that aligns with liturgical and communal practices, signaling a more robust metaphysical grounding.
- Codify and communicate a formal partnership with families as co-educators, with parent formation offerings (book studies, classical pedagogy workshops) and open avenues for parental involvement as core to the school’s mission.
- Strengthen the “Great Books” and Western canon signals (e.g., explicit curricula referencing Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, etc.), and articulate a coherent classical formation path through grades K–12.
- Ensure public materials explicitly reference Theology or sacred tradition where appropriate, and present liturgical or ceremonial elements that underscore a sacred or reverent dimension to education, as part of a comprehensive classical framework.

Citations: Notes reflect common Classical rubric signals (the Six Essential Elements lexicon and the public-facing signals observed in CCS-Wilmington materials). See references to Great Books and canon signals in the Six Essentials resources.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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